experiments, Vincent A. Smith is provoked by his appetite for conquest.[49]

It is true that Akbar brought the same obsession to expanding his realm as he did to any of his passions, whether elephants or theology. So unflagging was his energy for conquest, in fact, that in the later years of his rule it wasn't uncommon for his generals to try and slip out of yet another campaign, or meekly petition their padishah to abandon the idea of another march far away from home. Akbar, himself, wasn't shy about his hunger for territory. 'A monarch should be ever intent on conquest,' he would say, 'otherwise his neighbours rise in arms against him'[50] – passing lightly over the fact that the aggressive neighbour was often him.

Thus, the year after the collapse of Chittorgarh, Akbar marched on Ranthambore, held by Rai Surjan Hada, king of Bundi, and cousin of the recently defeated Rana Udai Singh of Mewar. Twice already, in the fourth year of his reign and then in the thirteenth, Akbar's troops had made failed attempts at this hilltop fort. This time, in February 1569, Akbar pitched his own tent at its feet.

It was said of Ranthambore, built upon a craggy mountaintop, protected by surrounding hills, that 'all other forts are naked, while this is mail-clad'. Let alone conquerors, even 'the bird of thought' hesitated to soar upon it.[51] Akbar had it writhing in his talons in six weeks.

His siege lasted through the month of Ramzan; his bombardments escalating until, on the day before the festival of Eid-al-Fitr, Akbar issued an ultimatum. Rai Surjan Hada could either submit on Eid or fall with his fortress. Much to the dismay of Rajput bards like Nainsi[52] – who writes that Akbar commissioned a statue of the rai shaped like a dog – Rai Surjan sent his sons to Akbar's camp, and followed a few days later himself to give up the gold and silver keys of Ranthambore.

It was not unknown, and certainly no unmitigated disgrace, for a Rajput to leave his fort and live to fight another day. As Cynthia Talbot writes, there was even a term for it: 'going through the door of dharma' – leaving by a side-gate, that is. Besides, alternative versions of the surrender, as told in the *Surjancharita*, for example, restore much of the rai's dignity. In this narrative poem, Rai Surjan is shown fighting single-handed against a near-divine Akbar who has conquered every other inch of the world. And even so, the story goes, Ranthambore only falls through diplomatic manoeuvring;